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The economy of Hausa communities of Zaria

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Where an unrelated person has the same name as a relative, kin or affinal, with whom Ego must observe name-avoidance, he will either use elliptical terms of denotation, or address and denote the non-relative by the appropriate kinship term for the relative, or call the non-relative by one of his other names. This is sometimes complicated further by the Hausa custom of regarding different names as synonymous; thus the names Garba and Abubakar are regarded by the Hausa as synonymous. If Ego's dan fari is called Muhammadu, Ego will address and refer to anyone called Muhammadu by another of their names or as "son of X"; because of the pronounced shame attached to the dan fari relationship, he will not refer to bearers of his firstborn's name as "dana" (my son). On the other hand, the terms "kala" (grandparent), uwana or tsohuwana (my mother) will be applied to any woman bearing the names of these kin. The difficulties of such a system of name-avoidances are met partly by the use of nicknames and partly by the use of such descriptive titles as Sarkin Hatsu (Chief cornbroker), Sarkin Awo (Chief dealer in threshed corn) and Sarkin Bariki (chief of the rest-house - i.e. caretaker). Similarly the play-association titles of childhood, which are often retained throughout life, reduce the embarrassments of name-avoidance, as do the profusion of nicknames which the Hausa bestow upon one another.

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Further refinements in naming will not be treated here. Briefly, the child receives, at its naming ceremony seven days after birth, its Koranic name (sunan litafi, the name of the Book), which is scrupulously allotted according to the week-day of birth. The week-day of birth also serves in many cases to provide a second, wholly Hausa nickname, such as Danjuma - "son of Friday" - from Juma'a, Friday; similarly the season of birth may be referred to, as Dankaka, "son of the dry season". The grandparents also have the right to give

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the infant the nickname by which it will be generally called, thus Maimuna, "the ugly one". There are also set pairs of names allotted to twins, who are regarded with pleasure as in some ways exceeding other children in fortune. As has been already mentioned, Hausa extend the behaviour appropriate to certain blood-relations to others, non-relatives, who bear the same name; thus, at the Mahommedan New Year a play extension of the grandparental joking relationship is made, and children and adults are free to collect small sums of ½d. or 1d. from anyone bearing the name of one of the collector's grandparents; the collector presents his grandparent's namesake with a piece of wood, saying "Ga itace, don tsoho ya ji dami" - "Here's wood so that the old man can keep warm", and the namesake in return gives the small coin - kudin shara (money of sweeping). Similarly a woman bearing one's mother's name may be addressed as "uwana", "my mother", and in some cases treated with a modified form of the behaviour proper to a mother.

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We may now comment briefly on some of the behavioural norms associated with these relationships.

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The complex of joking relationships (relationships holding between abokan wasa, lit. friends of play, sing. abokin wasa) falls into the following classes:

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(1) The fondness and play-relationship which links grandparents and grandchildren, and is standardised as a main motive for adoption.

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(2) The bilateral cross-cousin joking relationship which is expressed by the collection of kudin shara at the Mohammedan New Year, the child of the female sibling claiming ½d. or 1d. from the child of the male sibling because, as Hausa say, "the son of the male is the slave of the son of the female" ("Dan namiji, shi ne bawan dan tamace"). This crosscousin joking relationship occurs among the Hausa with preferred crosscousin marriage.

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(3) Joking relationships between the spouses of Ego's elder siblings of different sex and Ego, and also between the abokan wasa (cross-cousins and grandparents, particularly the former) of a spouse and his partner by marriage, tend to relieve the tensions inherent in affinal relationships and the conditions of Hausa marriage. Historical theories concerning these play-relationships and the levirate or sororate have been advanced by Dr. Greenberg as partial explanations of their present form and strength^{*}; these joking relations continue, though in diminished degree, after the divorce of the spouses on whom they were based.

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Kin Relationships

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External Relations

(4) Joking relationships between occupational groups were accompanied by preferred marriages between members of the groups, and a strong feeling of zumunta or mutual co-operation. Like all joking relationships, these were expressed annually in the custom of collecting kudin shara.

(5) Joking relationships between states or racial groups are said to have been accompanied by a permanent peace; they were regarded as the expression of linkages between such states or groups which stabilised the wider framework within which the Seven Hausa States ("Hausa bakwai") maintained their existence, by drawing sharp boundaries to the spread of war and by providing warring groups with the means of ending hostilities through the good offices of neutral groups linked by these ties to the parties concerned.

(6) Joking relationships between owners and their slaves served to relieve some of the tension inherent in their relations, as did the extension of kinship terms such as dan uwa to slaves.

[unavailable], J.H., Islam & Clan Organization among the Hausa, op. cit.,

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